

The Final Step: Perfecting a Document

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THE FINAL PRODUCT OF THE TECHNICAL COMMUNICATOR *should be as nearly error free as possible. Eliminating errors is never easy, but here the author describes a systematic approach based on proofreading fundamentals and organized into logical phases that should help all technical writers and editors.*

Typographical errors used to haunt me. Although I have a spell-checker on my word-processing software and a good proofreader in the word-processing center, ultimately, documents are *my* responsibility. The finger points only in one direction—at me.

Word-processing spell-checkers are a must, but they do not catch a “then” that should be a “the” or a “no” that should be a “now.” Nor do they catch verbs and subjects which—for some mysterious reason—just don’t agree. And even good in-house proofreaders can make errors, especially if they are not familiar with the content.

Ideally, one hires a professional proofreader. Unfortunately, budgets do not always permit this. And some documents, just by their nature, do not lend themselves to outside proofreading. In larger shops, a copy editor helps eliminate many errors and inconsistencies. “In traditional publishing houses,” writes Bruce C. Lewenstein, “proofreading is a two-person operation. One person reads the copy aloud to another” [1, 23]. In my case, and especially for my freelance work, I am the writer, the editor, the copy editor, and the “lay” proofreader—so I’m on my own.

Having found that the success of a document depends not only on technical accuracy and quality writing, but also on correct grammar, good appearance, stylistic consistency, and ease of use, I began paying a great deal of attention to detail. Sound familiar? Read on.

PROOFREADING FUNDAMENTALS

The following guidelines help minimize errors and take the “dread” out of proofreading while ensuring the best possible impact of a document.

Seek Out a Proof Buddy When I am confident that my draft is “ripe” for proofreading, I find a “proof buddy.” Basically I propose that I proof my buddy’s work and that my buddy proof mine. After working on a document for so long that I dream about it, I often miss even the most blatant of errors, whereas my buddy easily detects them.

Stick to a Style Guide Valerie Mitchell’s article “A Style Guide—Why and What” will convince you that if you do not already have a company “stylebook” in use, you should develop one that “. . . attempts to standardize spelling, punctuation, and word divisions [and] . . . gives preferable word choices and acceptable jargon. In general . . . [a stylebook] sets rules to follow, allows few exceptions, and chooses authoritative dictionaries and grammar books” [2]. For writers who have just come on board, style guidelines—coupled with a buddy system for proofreading—are especially helpful in teaching the use of terminology particular to an industry, products, services, and corporate conventions.

Prepare Yourself If I have to proof my own work, I let it “cool off” for a day or two, time permitting. Then I forward my phone, find the quietest place I can (preferably *not* my office),

surround myself with reference books, and start listing and “grouping” the items to check. More on the list and how I go about putting my “grouping” technique to work later. For now, here are just a few more fundamentals. The first is my favorite.

Take Breaks Taking breaks is vital. Since I tend to lose track of time, I set a timer and take a short break every twenty minutes. I call someone. I get coffee. I attend to something I have been postponing. I do anything to clear my mind and “re-sharpen” my detective skills.

Use a Mechanical Aid When working through documents, I use a straightedge such as a ruler or a thick piece of paper to help keep my focus on a single line [1, 24]. On longer documents, I prefer using a piece of paper so I can make notes on it and also indicate where I have stopped before taking a break (e.g., “Page 2, Paragraph 3”).

Make Changes Neatly When noting changes—especially if the corrections will not be made by me—I write neatly and explicitly. So that corrections will not be missed, I use red ink. If working on camera-ready proofs, I use a light blue pencil which the camera will not pick up.

Although some typesetters use proofreaders’ marks which they will make available to you, I find that many typesetters use their own systems of symbols and abbreviations. If in doubt, I check a style manual. Most style manuals include a section on proofreading and proofreaders’ marks. Whatever system is used, *clarity* and *consistency* avoid confusion and increase turnaround.

Keep a Copy Before turning over my proofed document to the person making the changes, I *always* keep a

copy of it so that I can quickly check the changes made. (Not keeping a copy just one time taught me that lesson.) If working with a typesetter, I request that the original be returned with the corrected copy.

Make the Last Check This is the last step—so tempting to forget when rushing to deliver a document. Once all indicated changes have been made, I check that no change has been omitted and that each change has been made as indicated. Taking the time to find errors and then forgetting to verify their correction is certainly counterproductive—if not plain “silly.”

LISTING AND GROUPING THE CHECKS

Keeping the fundamentals in mind, here is how I go about improving the proofreading process:

Make a “Core” List Since there are certain items to check in just about any document, I start with a standard or “core” list which I then customize to a particular document by adding or deleting items. Here’s an idea of what my core list includes:

Proper Nouns, Numbers, and Symbols

- Mathematical Operations
- Terminology
- Visual Aids, Charts, Columns
- Acronyms
- Trademarks/Service Marks

Cross-checks

- Cross-references
- Page Numbers
- Table of Contents
- Indexes
- Outlines
- Footnotes
- Bibliographies

Correct and Consistent Punctuation Typographical Faux Pas, Spelling, and Grammar Consistency

- Running Heads
- Footers
- Headings/Subheadings
- Type Sizes and Fonts
- Indentation
- Placement of Columns, Visual Aids, etc.

Appearance

- Layout
- Margins
- Packaging

Ease of Use

- Readability
- Ease of Reproduction

The core list above is not all-inclusive, and your list will, no doubt, differ from mine. What is important is being *organized*, i.e., developing a core list, adding detail, and customizing it to each document instead of “keeping it all in your head.”

Check Items in Logical Groups

One pass through the document to verify “everything” can make the checklist seem endless and the task of proofreading, unmanageable. So I facilitate the process by making several passes. In each pass through the document, (or section if, for example, it is a manual), I look for just the items in a particular “logical” group as noted above in my sample core list. Once I’ve completed one group, I move on to the next. Here’s how the grouping technique works:

• *Proper Nouns, Numbers, and Symbols.* I group proper nouns and numbers together because they are easy to spot as I move through the text. And since verification of names and numbers sometimes requires outside assistance, I tackle these first. When checking names and numbers, I take my *original* document and match each number and name to those appearing on the working draft. Although the original should be correct, if there is any doubt, I never trust the original or my memory. I pick up the phone and put my suspicions to rest. During this pass through the document, I also check any mathematical operations; I never assume they are correct.

When I am certain I have accurate information, I check for *consistency*. I start with terminology. For example, does “micro-computer” appear hyphenated throughout the document [1, 24-25]? Have I used more than one term for the same piece of equipment? Using the word “widget” to refer to an object in one place and then using “thingamajig” in another will confuse the reader and should be avoided in technical writing.

During this first pass, I also pay special attention to any visual aids such as diagrams and flow charts and make

sure that the text agrees with any terms, names, or numbers used in the artwork. Since the writer is rarely the artist, discrepancies between the copy and the artwork occur frequently and must be checked.

At the same time, I ask the following questions: Have I used the company name correctly throughout the document? Does it always appear in the same way? For example, in upper case? If using an acronym, have I informed the reader what it represents by spelling out the name and placing the acronym in parentheses behind it? Have I identified registered trademarks and/or service marks as required? Have I always spelled out numbers zero through nine? Fern Rook’s “About Numbers” article offers tips on using numbers correctly and consistently [3]. More detailed guidelines on the correct use of numbers can be found in a style manual such as *The Chicago Manual of Style*.

• *Cross-checks.* This is my “flip the pages” check. I group cross-reference, outline, footnote, and bibliographical checks together. I start by checking any references such as “See Page 13 for Additional Information” or “Refer to Diagram B-2.” These checks are extremely important when revising a document. Sometimes a diagram or a part of one is no longer used, yet the text continues to include the reference. Or the index includes a feature which is no longer available or a part which has been replaced.

In this same pass, I verify that page numbers in the table of contents and those in the index really do lead to the information referenced and that number sequences are, indeed, sequential. Even if you have software which automatically provides a table of contents, indexes, and outlines, these checks are well worth it—especially if typesetting.

Next I make sure that footnotes appear on the correct pages. I check that each note number is placed correctly in the text and that each corresponding footnote appears on the bottom of the appropriate page. I perform the same cross-check for numbered reference lists.

• *Correct and Consistent Punctua-*

nion. Having checked my cross-references, I start, again, at the beginning of the document and get nitpicky, but not too nitpicky for perfecting a document. Are words hyphenated correctly? If a comma is used before the last item in a series, is it always used? If quotes are used, are they all opened and closed correctly? Consistently?

If not typesetting, are there two spaces at the end of each sentence? (I was once amazed when a co-worker told me that only secretaries adhere to this rule!) If ever in doubt, I check my style manual. If still in doubt, I ask my proof buddy or peers.

• *Typographical Faux Pas, Spelling, and Grammar.* The next pass through the document is especially crucial when typesetting since the danger of omitting a letter, a word, a sentence, or even an entire section is increased. Most typesetters are very conscientious, but they do make mistakes, so it is always best to verify all proofs.

To check spelling and better detect typos, I begin by reading each word, one at a time, starting from the end of the document. By working backwards, one word at a time, I can focus on each word as a unit, not as a part of a meaningful sentence or phrase.

Then I start from the top again and slowly read, checking for grammatical errors, dropped or duplicated words, verb/subject agreement, etc. As I make this pass, I also try to catch any wording which still—in spite of my initial editing—may not make sense. Dennis E. Hensley recommends reading out loud. "Reading something aloud helps you gauge its rhythm, pace, sound, and degree of difficulty. If you discover that certain passages cause you to be tongue-tied or long-winded, rewrite them in more simplified language" [4].

• *Consistency.* As mentioned, the types and number of checks you will have to perform depend on the nature of the document; however, one of the keys to a professional document—no matter what the content, the format, the purpose, or the audience—is *consistency*. Lack of it is one of the most common problems which can be

avoided if you "keep in mind all that you have already read, or at least an awareness of what you have read. Pay attention, not to content, but to the physical document—the letters, the spacing, the punctuation" [1, 25].

When verifying consistency, I check the use of running heads, footers, headings, and subheadings. Are all letters in upper case? Bold? Underlined? Centered? Or left-justified? I also check consistency in type size and fonts, indentation, and the placement of columns and visual aids on pages.

• *Appearance.* Another key to a successful document, related to consistency, is *appearance*. Because appearance can be everything. I begin by simply looking at the document. Page by page. Section by section. And ask: Is the document "busy?" Has order been made out of chaos? Is there a page bursting with text while another is half-empty? If the document is to be "comb" bound, will the left margin be too wide? Are the margins balanced? If three-hole punching, will I punch right through the text?

When checking the "look" of a document, I ask my proof buddy and co-workers—especially those in the art department—for their opinions.

• *Ease of Use.* Now that the document "looks good," I ask if using it will be such a bother that no one will want to do so. Are the lines so long (over five and a half inches) that readers strain their eyes unnecessarily? Are folios printed so near the bottom of the page that they might not appear on photocopies? Was the printer or typewriter ribbon on its last leg? (Tucking away an extra ribbon—just for final copies—will help avoid last minute delays.)

CONCLUSION

My sample "grouping" of items is not magical or cast in stone. It, like my list of items to check, is provided as a guide for developing your own list, grouping system, and technique—a technique to follow relentlessly so as to copyedit/proofread systematically and therefore efficiently.

The final product of whatever you are writing—a letter, a proposal, a

manual, or technical specifications—is a reflection of you and your capabilities. So *make* the time to *make* the document as presentable as possible. Try to enlist someone to share and improve the task of proofreading. Be systematic. Develop your own list of checks to perform. Check items by logical groups. Whenever in doubt, use reference books. Ask the advice of co-workers. Take plenty of breaks. Whatever you do, do not let up once you have completed the research and the writing. Leaving no stone unturned will often make the difference between an effective, professional document and one that collects dust. Ω

REFERENCES

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3. Fern Rook, "About Numbers," *Technical Communication* 33, no. 4 (Fourth Quarter 1986): 266.
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